The Thagla Ridge reached higher elevations on its western side (overlooking the Tser Jang Tso) but the slopes to the Nam Ka Chu were more gentle. On the eastern side, towards the Nyamjang Chu junction, the valley was far steeper and the sharp rocky cliffs on the Chinese side made any approach from that direction impossible. From the Chinese deployment, it was obvious that the most vulnerable area was the frontage held by 2 Rajput.

The Chinese defences on the forward slope of the Thagla were in three tiers, the first being virtually on the river within grenade throwing distance of Bridges 1 to 4. A second line was dug in a few hundred yards behind and above them, while the main defences with mortars and MMGs were positioned around 600 metres above the river. Not only did this allow them to dominate the Nam Ka Chu Valley, it also allowed the Chinese to keep their eye on the Tsangdhar slope at the base of which were the Indian positions manned by elements of Assam Rifles, 9 Punjab, 4 Grenadiers, 2 Rajput and 1/9 Gorkha Rifles that constituted 7 Brigade under the command of Brigadier John Dalvi.

The Nam Ka Chu originated from a glacier-fed lake, Tser Jang Tso, situated at an altitude of 13,600 feet. The river flowed eastwards, dropping sharply down to 7,100 feet over a distance of sixteen kilometres, an extremely sharp descent even by Himalayan standards. At various points, the Nam Ka Chu had wooden logs spanning the waters, acting as makeshift bridges across it. These became important features around which the units of 7 Brigade were deployed. At the highest point, after the river flowed out of Tser Jang Tso, was Bridge 5 that had one company of 9 Punjab deployed next to it. Further downstream was Temporary Bridge that had Charlie Company of 2 Rajput less a platoon. However, a platoon from Delta Company brought them back to full company strength. After a gap, Bravo Company was deployed at Log Bridge, followed by the Battalion HQ at Bridge 4. This location was protected by Delta Company that was also at full strength with men from the Charlie Company platoon in its ranks. At Bridge 3 was Alpha Company with an additional platoon of Assam Rifles under its command. The entire frontage of 2 Rajput extended across almost four kilometres, from Temporary Bridge to Bridge 3.

Further downstream, to the right of the 2 Rajput position, was 7 Brigade HQ with a company of 1/9 GR protecting its location. Bridge 2 and Bridge 1 had a larger concentration of troops. 9 Punjab less one company was